

P. M. Morgan Deterrence: A Conceptual Analysis 2nd ed.
Sage 1983

INTRODUCTION

Deterrence involves manipulating someone's behavior by threatening him with harm. The behavior of concern to the deterrer is an attack; hence, deterrence involves the threat to use force in response as a way of preventing the first use of force by someone else. Manipulation via threat captures the essence of deterrence, and manipulation of this sort would appear to be a rather primitive relationship. As such it is not a practice that readily fits into the framework of a sophisticated, civilized society. We are most comfortable applying it in dealing with primitives. These include opponents who "will not see reason" and stubbornly persist in their views or foreigners who, in a conflict, are often pictured as crude and barbaric, not quite human ("the only thing they understand is force"). An example of a domestic primitive is the criminal, in particular the ghetto criminal, against whom we practice deterrence through the law and incarceration. Primitives are those who, for one reason or another, have only a limited capacity for rationality and so must be threatened because other methods, such as persuasion, will not work. (We consider using force and threats to train children and pets for the same reason). Some barrier to effective communication and cooperation on a more subtle basis is perceived, leading us to resort to a much cruder device.

In international politics we find ourselves in an age when deterrence as the foundation of national security ultimately rests on a readily available capacity to wreck many of the world's greatest civilizations. Ours has been a century preoccupied with the exploration, display, and frequent glorification of the primitive in human behavior, culminating in international relationships marked by gigantic world wars and pitiless small ones. Atomic weapons capped a revolution in weaponry that had made war progressively less tolerable, yet the history of the century was a showcase of insensitivity to that fact. The answer seemed to be use of this frightful new weapon to sustain deterrence, a primitive tactic but quite possibly pitched at the proper level to keep the primitives on the other side in line. Eventually the same function was

extended to non-nuclear weapons as well, partly out of a fear that a non-nuclear war might well escalate.

Intellectuals were not slow to respond to the need for some theoretical raiment in which to garb deterrence, and they produced an imposing body of theory to offer instruction on the acquisition, deployment, and alternative uses of a wide range of contemporary weapons and forces. To control the primitive in an age of the primitive, one would expect the most suitable starting point to be a model that sought to tap or allow for the non-rational, subconscious, or instinctual roots of perception, thought, and behavior. But one striking feature of deterrence theorizing was that, while it arose out of an era often displaying mankind at its worst, it proceeded via assumptions about behavior typical of more optimistic centuries. Theorizing about the uses of violent threats, oddly enough, started by depicting the prospectively violent as rational men engaged in rational decision making. One would have expected something with a whiff of Freud, not the Philosophes. In many ways it was strongly reminiscent of the labors of Machiavelli, the theorist of an earlier brutal and violent age who sought to describe the rational use of violence, cunning, and deceit in pursuit of highly moral objectives.

It is hard to make deterrence fit with other major elements in the history and experience of this century. Contemporary scientific and literary penetration into the subtleties and complexities of human relationships hardly supports the simple notions of motivation at the heart of deterrence theory. Even Skinnerian psychology, to which deterrence theory may seem related, would not describe the link between threats of pain and behavior in terms of rationality. We are burdened in this century with a heightened sensitivity to the limitations of rationality and the conscious control of social behavior. Also, this has been a war-ridden century. Unless we want to believe that in each case war broke out because deterrence was mistakenly applied or not attempted, we have good grounds for suspecting that deterrence will not always work.

With the coming of nuclear weapons it was at least possible that the goal of war avoidance would be achieved because those weapons would impel a widespread perception of the impossibility of war. There have been some societies, more than we would like to think, that have made war one of the core elements of their social life. But most societies, including our own, have been impressed by how terrible war can be. On the other hand, they have also regarded war as acceptable, even noble, under certain circumstances. If war is possibly awful but not impossible, it becomes an intermittent activity; attention need be paid to the state's military forces only on occasion. The armed forces will be built up only when danger threatens or a conflict has already broken out. Before then, military men are apt to find themselves on short

rations. In foreign affairs the state will rely on non-military means for dealing with the great bulk of its problems, even serious ones, because while the state has military power in reserve, that power is a long way in reserve and would be expensive, time-consuming, and dangerous to bring to bear.

Introduction of nuclear weapons into a world of such states might nudge the specialists on war into unemployment as war passed from an activity occasionally useful and usable under certain conditions into one completely unacceptable. War would become, like slavery or colonialism, an ancient practice the world could no longer sustain. The result would be war avoidance via the opposite of the kinds of military arrangements that sustain deterrence. But such an outcome almost certainly has, as its prerequisite, the existence of an international system and structure widely accepted as legitimate. Otherwise the cleavages among states will be perceived as threats to their national security and survival, necessitating a capability for war no matter how distasteful.

This is, in fact, how we ended up in the embrace of nuclear deterrence. After Hiroshima and Nagasaki there were assertions that these weapons outlawed war. However meant, they turned out to be simply expressions of hope. There were some feeble attempts to control nuclear weapons and warfare through the United Nations, on the supposition that everyone could be brought to agree that the common good necessitated it, but no one really expected success. Tackling such a problem as if everyone can see it is time to do so implies (and reinforces) the existence of a world community. Given the cold war atmosphere of the times and the nature of Stalin's government, it is understandable that this approach could not take hold; there seemed to be no way to common ground with the Soviet Union over the unacceptability of war. It proved impossible to put war abhorrence at the service of war avoidance in any other way than under the rubric of deterrence. The necessary consensus was lacking, and so we turned to deterrence as the next best bet. What we have failed to sufficiently appreciate was that it was a bad bet, however unavoidable it may have seemed at the time.

The recognition of deterrence as the primary mission of military forces came slowly. Then technical improvements in the spread and reach of nuclear and conventional forces made it necessary to think in terms of a military capability constantly primed for action. Armed forces could no longer exist largely on paper and in mobilization plans but had to be constituted as ever-present formations and weapons. Side effects of this change included an adjustment in the processes of making foreign policy. First, the role of the military in policy making was enhanced by its omnipresence, by the weight a sizable military force could accumulate for use in bureaucratic political struggles, by the support of the domestic allies it inevitably acquired, and by

the natural efforts of the armed forces at public relations and self-aggrandizement. Attention paid to military views and needs in policy and in the allocation of resources increased substantially in comparison with earlier periods in the nation's history. This brought a tendency to define national security almost entirely in terms of military force and power. As Charles Frankel has wisely written, we can hardly afford the true costs involved.

We have not yet learned to measure the costs of foreign policy by an appropriate standard. We invoke something called "the national interest," and mean by it essentially the taking of precautions that will keep possible adversaries at a disadvantage. And since there is no limit to the damage they want to do us, and no limit, in abstract theory, to their possible capacity at some time or other to do what they might imaginably want, there is no limit to the precautions which, in this view of the world, it is necessary and reasonable to take. And so, to ward off possible nightmares in the future, we have followed policies that involve us in nightmares in the present.

The costs of this manner of thinking are not to be figured in the national budget alone, immense though they are. They include the excessive centralization of government and the economy, the removal of major domains of national policy from close inspection by the electorate, and the neglect of problems at home and abroad more immediately and profoundly threatening to the national security. None of these is the inexorable consequence of our social system. All are the consequences of policies that overorganize and overextend it for the business of war.¹

This is not a pattern solely to be found in recent American history. It is of little comfort to know that in the Soviet Union, despite repeated efforts of the political leadership to confine military influence, the requirements and pressures of deterrence have recently propelled the Ministry of Defense into a power and prominence (in peacetime), as reflected in budgets and weapons, unmatched since 1917.

Of course, the availability of forces makes resort to force a much more plausible option for foreign policy purposes than would otherwise be the case. Forces developed with deterrence in mind are available for less laudable purposes. Those designed to deter a major opponent can be put to use coercing third parties. These forces can be mustered in an attempt to bolster positions in conflicts that fall short of war (though evidence as to their effectiveness here is not plentiful). Eventually this led to attempts in theory as well as weapons design and deployment to make the most fearsome weapons more "usable"—from flexible response and limited nuclear war options to development of mini-nukes and clean nuclear weapons.

These side effects are the source of many apparent anomalies that surround us. In an era when war would be terrible, the threat to resort to force continues to be used. Such threats can still be used at times for political purposes, reinforcing the tendency to define national security in military terms, not only for great powers but also for smaller ones. Thus a second anomaly is heavy military spending by minor powers at a time when the disparity between the gross military might they can hope to possess and that of the major powers is simply vast.

This is also why there is an inverse relationship in our era between the general acceptability of war and the influence of specialists in military violence within societies and policy making circles. In the same way there is a startling contrast between the acceptability of war in the abstract and the actual size of the world's standing armed forces and military budgets. The last of these anomalies is that the vast destructiveness of a single nuclear weapon does not mean that a few will suffice; instead we have enormous numbers of such weapons and huge expenditures on non-nuclear forces. These are some of the consequences of having had to rely on deterrence.

These are rather severe side effects with which to contend, particularly since we risk freezing nations into a semi-permanent military competition that may force the deterrence balance onto consistently higher plateaus of weaponry and potential destructiveness. The might, nevertheless, be acceptable if deterrence would be counted on to work and if deterrence theory were enhancing our prospects for survival. Unfortunately, there are grounds for doubting that either is the case. Deterrence is a "hair of the dog" cure for war, arming to preserve us from clashes of arms, and in the long view makes just about as much sense. Deterrence theory takes threat and reaction, a complex psychological phenomenon with obvious roots in the emotional equipment of man, and reduces it to the interaction of a set of rational decision makers.

Classic criticisms of deterrence theory turn on the charge that governments simply lack the necessary rationality to make it work, that they are particularly subject to irrationality in times of intense crisis or actual attack. For a number of reasons, these criticisms of deterrence theory have never fully taken hold, perhaps because of the general impression that deterrence does exist, so that to abandon deterrence theory as it stands is to have no handle on an important phenomenon. Proponents have defended their theorizing with the argument that the assumption of rationality is a simplifying one that aids in construction of a theory that, while not perfect, is both moderately accurate and of considerable use to decision makers.

There is another perspective on deterrence we can adopt, one that searches for a more accurate description of just how deterrence works as the basis for suggestions as to when and where deterrence is likely to fail. This is the view

that deterrence rests less on the capacities of men for rationality than on their ability to be conscious of their limitations and adjust their behavior accordingly. It involves the ability of leaders to recognize a variety of limits: on the amount and quality of available information and on the ability of any government to process it effectively; on the rationality of individual and group decisions; on the government's ability to implement decisions in an effective and consistent way. What results is a process of decision and action that eschews large steps for small ones, that favors reversible over irreversible steps, that seeks to minimize risks of serious consequences primarily by taking steps that are expected to have but a limited impact. It is pragmatic, relatively short term in focus, and flexible because it often avoids commitment. This sort of behavior by leaders has often been detected by analysts but almost never consistently applied to the analysis of deterrence. Herbert Simon refers to one aspect of it as "satisficing," as opposed to the maximizing of pure rational decision models; Daniel Moynihan labels it "coping"; Charles Lindblom and David Braybrooke call it "disjointed incrementalism"; while John Steinbruner talks about "uncommitted thinking."²

I refer to it as "sensible" decision making, having in mind the commonly drawn distinction between raw intelligence and common sense. The sensible decision maker will seldom find the conditions right for war and thus is not easily brought to the point of starting one. He will be impressed by the risks, the incalculables, his own and his advisors' limitations, and the unpredictability of the opponent's and other states' reactions. Such decision makers are perfect targets for deterrence threats—the threat helps induce all those feelings that discourage a decision for war.

Deterrence then becomes an attempt to use threats of retaliation to induce "sensible" decision making in a severe crisis, to get an opponent to make a decision on whether or not to attack in a way that would pretty much rule out taking such a drastic and uncertain step. A signal defect in deterrence is that it is practiced on governments that have already given some thought to an attack, that is, some set of circumstances has had the effect of making it entirely possible that such a non-incremental step could be taken.

Once deterrence is depicted in this fashion some of its other flaws and weak spots also become fairly obvious. Threats may be somewhat incompatible with the objective of encouraging a government to remain sensible—threats may provoke an extreme reaction. For another, deterrence may have to be practiced against a government not normally given to being sensible because it is in the hands of leaders willing to take large risks or supremely confident in their visions and abilities. In fact, sensible governments may be expected to find ways to avoid all-out confrontations where war is a serious possibility so that many such confrontations require that deterrence be

attempted against the "wrong" sort of government. Next, a crisis is almost by definition a situation where business as usual does not obtain, where a normally cautious government may consider it appropriate to risk more momentous decisions.

Finally, the most dangerous crisis of all would be one that emerged incrementally as the two sides took small steps in hopes of avoiding war but found that they had been brought to the brink of one nonetheless. At that point, the large step of uncertain consequences that is very difficult to take may be what is needed to break off the confrontation, while resorting to force (particularly on a limited scale) may seem like only a modest departure from the status quo. I am thinking here of the early stages of American military involvement in the Vietnam war, when various presidents found themselves in a situation in which sending advisors or more troops was an incremental decision, whereas taking serious steps to disengage required a decision of substantial, quite possibly harmful, consequences.

None of these circumstances is at all uncommon in international politics. Thus deterrence works some of the time, but our confidence in it is misplaced. The key contribution of a theory of deterrence should be to point out how it works, and thus how tenuous it can be, to encourage steps to reduce the damage if it fails, and ultimately to encourage efforts to move away from reliance on deterrence. As it stands, deterrence theory does not really do this. By encouraging attempts to engage in carefully rational decision making in a crisis, measuring and weighing costs and benefits as if there were precise measures and exact scales, it can heighten the risks of war by upping the confidence of leaders that they know what they are doing and can control the situation. In oversimplifying the nature of the decision making involved, it develops insufficiently subtle models of the impact of threats on international relationships. Finally, deterrence theory has been available to rationalize a weapons buildup unjustified for the purposes of credible deterrence—justifying overkill capacities that expand the possible costs of war without thereby enlarging the national security. It is my hope that this book will contribute to a better understanding of deterrence in theory and practice, an understanding that will lead us to reconsider our willingness to continue entrusting our fate to our capacities for violence.

NOTES

1. Charles Frankel, *High on Foggy Bottom* (New York: Harper and Row, 1968), pp. 238-239.

2. Herbert Simon, *Models of Man* (New York: John Wiley, 1957); Daniel Moynihan, *Coping, On the Practice of Government* (New York: Vintage, 1975); David Braybrooke and Charles Lindblom, *A Strategy of Decision: Policy Evaluation as a Social Process* (New York: Free Press, 1963); John Steinbruner, *The Cybernetic Theory of Decision* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1974).

Chapter 1

THE SUBJECT

This is a book about deterrence in international politics. Primarily it is about what we think we mean when we use the term and how that thinking might be improved. Having spent much time and effort on this opus, I can report that it was not an easy task. A vast amount of literature clogging library shelves had to be surveyed, accounting for some of the difficulty. Then came the standard hassles involved in getting notions and knowledge down on paper. But perhaps the chief difficulty was a persistent belief, on my part as well as others, that deterrence itself was a relatively straightforward thing.

Of course, everyone knows what deterrence is—the use of threats of harm to prevent someone from doing something you do not want him to. Nothing very complicated about that idea—people dislike harm, so they shy away from actions which promise harm. Most of us first come face to face with it as children—confronting threats of spanking to keep us out of the cookie jar or from self-expression in crayon on the wall. Later we resort to it in dealing with our own children. It even seems to work with animals, in housebreaking the puppy and getting the cat to stop climbing up the drapes. The complications involved would seem to concern not the central idea of deterrence, apparently simple, but finding the right means for implementing it—how best to threaten and, if it fails, to punish.

It took me some time to realize that the problem is not just in the implementation; there are serious difficulties and ambiguities with the very

idea of deterrence. As far as I can see, these problems get worse when attention is shifted from everyday relationships to those among governments. I know of no satisfactory discussion of such matters in the existing literature on national security; having set out to remedy this deficiency, I wish I could guarantee that the matter has been cleared up, that all reading this will sigh with satisfaction at the light that has been shed. Needless to say, there "ain't no guarantee." I am not even satisfied with the results myself; I just hope I am on the right track. As initial evidence that deterrence is not a clear and precise notion, I offer the following introductory comments, which also serve as a guide to topics and problems taken up in some of the chapters to come.

Let us begin by working through a sample of the many extant definitions of deterrence to see what they tell us and, more significantly, what remains unclear. One of the many available discussions of the subject begins by suggesting that deterrence can refer to two things, a policy and a situation.

A policy of deterrence is a calculated attempt to induce an adversary to do something, or refrain from doing something, by threatening a penalty for non-compliance. A deterrence situation, or system, is one where conflict is contained within a boundary of threats which are neither executed nor tested.¹

Notice that under this definition deterrence has to do with *conflict*, involves a relationship between *adversaries*, and centers on the use of *threats*. These seemingly simple points are actually rather important, particularly the matter of adversaries. The reason is that many conceptions of power turn, roughly speaking, on one party controlling another's access to various values in order to direct the other's behavior. This naturally includes both punishment and the threat of it; also, to win compliance by rewarding someone inevitably carries with it the hidden threat that at some point the reward will be withdrawn or not renewed. This idea of power can, of course, apply among friends or acquaintances, not just outright opponents. Thus if we do not insist that deterrence pertains to *conflicts* between *adversaries* we are in danger of treating it as a synonym for power, a nasty thought since power is an exceedingly broad phenomenon, the proper delimitation of which has often bedeviled analysis. It is to our benefit to confine deterrence to a much narrower set of relationships.

Another way of narrowing the applicability of deterrence, in which the above definition is of no help, would be to specify the nature of the adversaries: individuals, groups, or governments. Why is this important? Leaving the parties unspecified carries with it the implication that deterrence can occur in conflict at any level, which suggests a fundamental similarity in conflict itself wherever it occurs. The trouble with this is that we cannot be

certain it is true, despite attempts to study conflict at many levels as related aspects of a single phenomenon.²

The term "deterrence" is mostly used in connection with severe conflicts between national governments. If we want to retain a specific focus for the inquiry, it would be wise to retain this practice. It also helps us avoid a related problem: If we suspect that conflict at many levels is very similar, then behavior or practices typical of domestic disputes or family quarrels may be cited to illuminate deterrence in international conflict. The temptations to do this are of almost sinful proportions and must, in good conscience, be resisted—more accurately, transferring observations from one level to another must be done with great care.

There is another problem with this definition. It separates a deterrence *policy* from a deterrence *situation*. This is a distinction that appears to break down under careful scrutiny. My inclination is to assert that a deterrence *situation* is one in which at least one party to the conflict is following a *policy* of deterrence. In fact, as the next chapter will indicate, this is the only way I have been able to make any headway in refining the concept—by specifying the characteristics of a deterrence situation in terms of what the adversaries within it are doing.

Here is part of another definition from a recent text in national security policy matters.

Simply put, deterrence means that State A seeks to prevent State B from doing Z by threatening B with unacceptable costs if it does Z.³

There are several comments we can make at this point. As we see, under this definition the adversaries we have in view are states, a useful delimitation of the conflicts to which "deterrence" can apply. Another point opens up a large and uncertain subject: If deterrence involves one state threatening in order to affect the behavior of another, this implies that, at least in certain situations, a state is guided far more by influences from the *outside* world than *domestic* factors. Any randomly selected roomful of foreign policy specialists will contain several who do not accept this perspective. Attempting to take their viewpoint into account will complicate our subject nicely. Finally, in both this definition and the preceding one, the action that is unacceptable to one party, and which it seeks to deter, is unspecified. In fact the preceding definition talks about inducing the opponent "to do something" as well as not do something. As I see it, the problem here is this: Since any threat by one state is aimed at getting another state to do or not to do something, does this mean that all threats are deterrent threats? Some of the following chapter is devoted to arguing that, in effect, no one who uses the

term really intends it to mean this at all—that they have in mind certain kinds of threats to prevent certain kinds of actions.

We can partially anticipate some of that later discussion by considering a brief definition of deterrence offered by Morton Halperin:

The most pervasive notion [in strategy today] is that of “deterrence:” that the primary function of military force should be to prevent the use of military force by one’s opponents.⁴

Here we move to talking about a *military* threat in order to prevent *military* action. It cannot be denied that in all our public discourse on foreign policy this is, almost exclusively, the context in which “deterrence” is discussed; other kinds of pressures (threatened aid cutoffs, for example) are not included.

However, the Halperin definition is rather vague as to what kind of action might be involved. For instance it would permit us to label as deterrence a policy of preemptive attack completely destroying the opponent’s military forces. That would “prevent the use of military force by one’s opponents” all right! But it completely contradicts standard usage of the term.

The following definition avoids that problem and pulls a number of preceding points together, though not without exposing still other difficulties.

“To deter” literally means to stop someone from doing something by frightening him. . . . dissuasion by deterrence operates by frightening a state out of attacking, not because of the difficulty of launching an attack and carrying it home, but because the expected reaction of the opponent will result in one’s own severe punishment.

In a simple two-party situation, state A’s deterrent force accomplishes its purpose by frightening state B out of making the military strike that it would have made had the deterrent threat been ineffective.⁵

There is much to be gained by giving this definition a careful rereading. A number of elements are familiar: Deterrence is a matter between states, involving the threat of force to prevent military action. But the kind of action to be prevented is now specified—an *attack*, by state B. This is rather important because B could use its military forces in lots of ways, doing a variety of things (mobilize, maneuver, threaten to attack, physically defend itself), and state A could use threats to try to prevent any of them. Now we see that only an *attack* is the object of a deterrent threat, a point we return to in the next chapter.

Next, this definition talks about an “expected reaction” by state A to an attack. A deterrent threat has to do with responding, with “punishment” *after* an attack. Obviously this would rule out a preemptive strike, as well as any attempt by an aggressive state to use a military threat to coerce another into surrendering something without a fight.

However, some ambiguities still remain. Is it possible to distinguish between deterrence and simply being ready to fight if attacked? Some display a tendency to treat the two as synonymous: Secretary of Defense Laird used to refer to our entire military posture as “realistic deterrence,” making deterrence the equivalent of being “prepared.” The Swiss in an earlier day and Sweden in our time are often cited to illustrate how military preparedness has deterred incursions on their neutrality.

The trouble with this lies in the idea that deterrence involves “punishment” or rather the threat of it. The concept of deterrence came to prominence with the appearance of nuclear weapons precisely because they made it possible for a state under attack to do great harm to the attacker even without really defending itself. In other words, to fight back when attacked is one kind of response, but to reach out and harm the attacker in retribution is another—and it is the latter that is most closely associated with deterrence. This is the basis for the widespread acceptance of a distinction between deterrence and defense in the literature. It is also one reason why deterrence via nuclear weapons is often seen as qualitatively different from deterrence with conventional forces.

Yet there is more to be said on this matter. Classically, and for non-nuclear armed states today, deterrence has been invoked by the *threat of war*, which implied the possibility of both defense and retribution. In fact, even among nuclear powers a deterrence threat in a specific conflict is almost always, formally, no more specific than the promise of “grave consequences.” The punishment that will result is unspecified, to be inferred from the deterrer’s military capabilities, which include some capacity both for defending itself and punishing the enemy. This would seem to erode the distinction between deterrence and defense, or at least to suggest it may be the sort academicians delight in detecting which is of little relevance to the real world. Thus, this is a subject we must return to later.

Next, and perhaps most important, in the definition we are now considering the threat is described as effective *because it induces fear*. Nothing remarkable about that, at first glance; after all, we worry about the “balance of terror” at the heart of international politics. The reason that I call attention to it is that deterrence theory has never simply asserted that deterrent threats may prevent attack; its proponents have also offered an explanation as to *why* this is so. Well, why *do* deterrent threats work? Compare the reason just offered—fear—with what follows:

One requirement for deterrence is that decision-makers act rationally—the leaders of State B must calculate the costs and benefits of the action that State A is seeking to deter and rationally conclude not to act.⁶

What happened to fear? It is not even mentioned; it seems that a rational calculation on the part of the opponent is involved (something often considered distinct from, even the opposite of, fear). Perhaps the central ambiguity in existing analyses of deterrence is that they are not at all consistent in explaining how a deterrent threat works. For some analysts, fear is a key ingredient.⁷ For others it is the rational assessment of costs and gains.⁸ Still others introduce uncertainty and risk as important elements.⁹ Naturally enough, some refer to several of these elements operating simultaneously.¹⁰

But this is only part of the problem. To explain how deterrence works is to attempt to tell us something about how governments work. That relates in turn to how one would explain what brings a government to a decision to attack and thus to be the target of a deterrent threat. If we believe such a threat induces fear that turns a government away from attacking, then it is not illogical to suggest that powerful emotional/psychological forces may have been behind the possible attack in the first place. On the other hand, if cost/gain calculations are the heart of the matter when it comes to deterrence, it is not unlikely this also pertains to other decisions.

The difficulties entailed here are reflected in the following definition.

Deterrence is the inducement of another party . . . to refrain from a certain action by means of a threat that this action will lead the threatener . . . to inflict retaliation or punishment. . . . In other words deterrence is persuading the deterred that his own interest compels him to desist from committing a certain act.

Such persuasion is achieved by calculations of gain against loss. . . . To make deterrence effective, the deterrer makes certain that the level of retaliation . . . overrides the gain the deterred anticipates. . . . To the extent that such an action is motivated by psychological impulse rather than calculations of gain, the strength of the deterrent threat must of course also offset the pressure of such impulses.¹¹

Most of the definition has us working in a world of rational calculation. The kicker comes in the last sentence; suddenly we shift to a situation in which a "psychological impulse rather than calculations of gain" is what a deterrent threat must contend with. Herman Kahn talks in much the same way when he calls for enough retaliatory forces to deter a rational opponent and then adds

that we would want additional forces in order to deter "even the irrational and irresponsible."¹² How something that works *because leaders are rational* applies as well when they are not is never really made clear.

To restate the problem in the broadest terms, deterrence theory has to be considered a kind of decision making theory, telling us something about how governments reach decisions. Alas, there are plenty of available models of the decision process, many of which vary a good deal from those utilized in deterrence thinking. How does this affect the way we see deterrence working? This is the question at the core of this book; it recurs in various guises in most of the chapters that follow.

There is one last problem that cannot be solved; the best anyone can do is work around it. It is reflected in the question: How will we know a deterrence situation when we see it? There are various kinds of sheep's clothing in which this wolf hides, but it is the same wolf nonetheless. One is the case of the unvoiced threat—what if state B simply assumes that state A will certainly threaten to retaliate, and will retaliate, if it should become necessary and takes this into account in deciding not to make any trouble. Is that an example of deterrence?

A second is the case of the ambiguous inhibition. State A threatens state B with retaliation, and sure enough B does not attack. But when queried as to why, the leaders of state B respond indignantly that as they are honest and upright such a thought never entered their minds. Besides, says one privately, "we were too busy with other things" to think seriously of attacking. In the absence of any conclusive evidence, do we consider this an instance of deterrence or do we not? Is the mere presence of the threat sufficient, or is deterrence the result of the threat having a particular impact?

As numerous analysts have noted, to conclusively demonstrate that deterrence worked (or is working) means proving why something did not happen (is not happening). As that is never really possible, it is very difficult to be certain what to count as a case of successful deterrence, which puts a crimp in comparing successes with failures in order to refine deterrence in both theory and practice. Of course this has been the source of many policy disputes, such as the long-standing struggle over the value of stationing large American forces in Europe. And it forces us to ask, as already indicated: How will we know it when we see it?

Let me conclude this chapter with a brief summary of what can be found in the others. Chapter 2 contains an attempt to distinguish two kinds of "deterrence situations" as the basis for understanding when and how deterrence exists. The one that follows illustrates the ways in which varying our conception of decision making alters, in a most basic manner, our notion of how deterrence works. Next, the book turns to exploring rational decision

models as the basis for a theory of deterrence, settling on one as preferable while rejecting the others as inadequate. Yet another chapter attempts to incorporate some of the insights in the recent literature on crisis decision making and on the causes of war into what will have become, by then, a rather elaborate new conception of deterrence. The final chapter, added for this edition, offers further reflections and incorporates some recent findings.

NOTES

1. Roy E. Jones, *Nuclear Deterrence, A Short Political Analysis* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1968), p. 1.
2. See, for example, Roy L. Prosterman, *Surviving to 3000, An Introduction to the Study of Lethal Conflict* (Belmont, Calif.: Duxbury Press, 1972).
3. Eugene Rosi (ed.), *American Defense and Detente* (New York: Dodd Mead, 1973), p. 96.
4. Morton Halperin, *Defense Strategies for the Seventies*, 2nd edition (Boston: Little, Brown, 1971), p. 10.
5. Robert J. Art and Kenneth N. Waltz, "Technology, Strategy, and the Uses of Force," in R. J. Art and K. N. Waltz, *The Use of Force* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1971), p. 6.
6. Rosi (note 3), p. 96.
7. Bernard Brodie, *War and Politics* (New York: Macmillan, 1973), pp. 430-431 talks about the "lurking fear" it will fail as a major factor making deterrence work.
8. See William Kaufmann, *The Requirements of Deterrence*, Center of International Studies Memorandum No. 7 (Princeton, 1954), p. 7; or Colin Gray, "The Urge to Compete: Rationales for Arms Racing," *World Politics* Vol. 26 No. 2 (January 1974), p. 210.
9. For example, Glenn Snyder, "Deterrence and Power," *Journal of Conflict Resolution* Vol. 4, No. 2, pp. 163-178.
10. Andre Beaufre, *Deterrence and Strategy* (New York: Praeger, 1966), pp. 24-25 combines *calculation* and *fear*. Bernard Brodie, *Strategy in the Missile Age*, 1st edition (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1959), p. 279 combines *calculation* and *uncertainty*.
11. Y. Harkabi, *Nuclear War and Nuclear Peace* (Jerusalem: Israel Program for Scientific Translations, 1966), p. 9.
12. Among other places where he expresses this view, see Herman Kahn, *Thinking About the Unthinkable* (New York: Horizon Press, 1962), p. 112.